IWAE User Guide

Read, highlight, turn it into notes, and jump back to the source.

This guide is a practice field

This PDF comes with every new Vault as an example. Highlight it, capture from it and translate it as you read. The "Try it" boxes tell you what to do. Anything you mark while practicing can be undone with `Ctrl` + `Z` or deleted at any time.

Start here

1. In the left bar, under "Note", click **Tour of IWAE**. The memos already attached to this guide open in a note tab. Press `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `M` to put it beside the document.
2. Click a memo card. The PDF jumps to the sentence it was written for.
3. Click a page number in the contents below to go to a chapter, and follow its "Try it" steps.

Highlight, get a memo

Select text and a highlight and a memo appear together, linked to the source by a line.

Read side by side

Panes and screens put several documents in view.

Stays on your PC

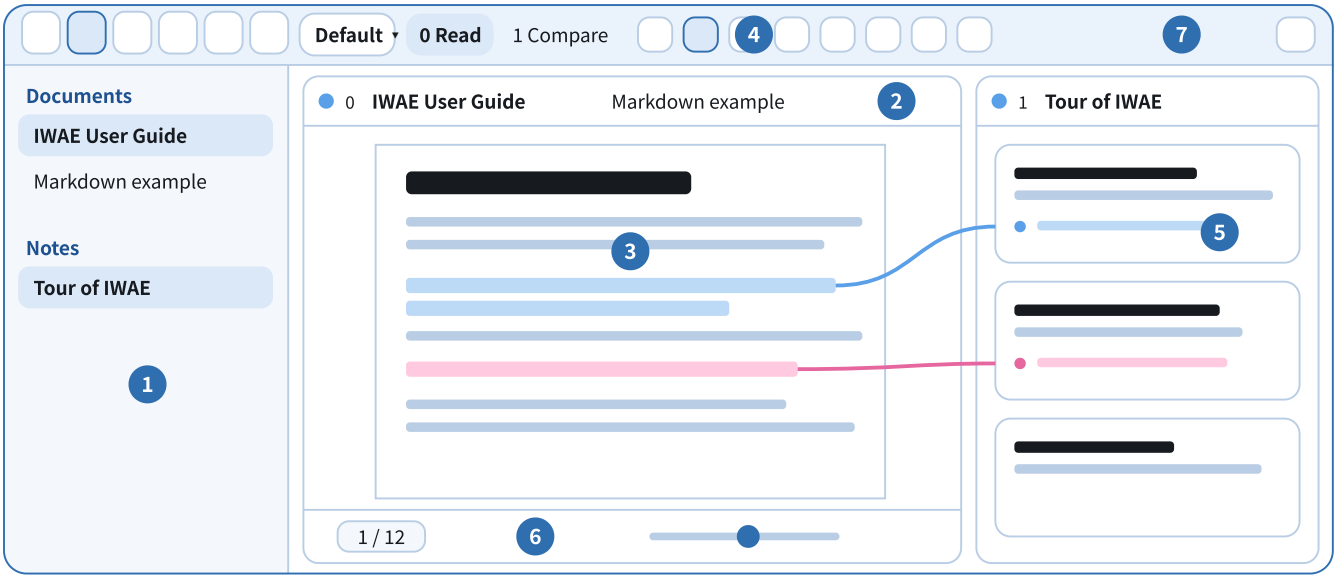
Your documents stay in your folder, and so do the app's records.

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At a glance

IWAE turns what you mark in PDFs and Markdown into notes that point back to the source.



1 Left bar	Lists documents and notes. Tabs in the top row switch its view.
2 Pane head	Holds the color dot, the pane number and the tab bar. Drag the head to move the pane.
3 Document pane	Reads PDFs and Markdown. Split panes to read several documents side by side.
4 Toolbar	The tools of the pane you are using appear in the top row.
5 Note pane	A note is a tab too and opens in its own pane. Memo cards link to PDF highlights by lines.
6 Bottom bar	One per document pane. Page navigation, fit width, fit page, fit height, zoom.
7 Top row	The session name, the screen tabs and the translator button.

The basic loop

1 Highlight
Drag over text and a highlight is painted.

›

2 Memo
A memo card opens in the note.

›

3 Linked
A line joins the card and the highlight.

›

4 Jump back
Click the card and the PDF returns to that spot.

Feature map

I want to…	Go to
Open documents and put them side by side	p. 3 · p. 4
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1 Vault and screen

IWAE opens a single folder called a Vault.

Your PDFs and Markdown files stay in that folder, and the app keeps its own records in a `.iwae` folder inside it. A Vault is a plain folder, so you can copy or back it up with your file manager. Nothing is locked inside the app. If you uninstall IWAE, your files are still there.

Inside the Vault folder

Path	Contents
`*.pdf` · `*.md`	Your documents. Subfolders appear in the left list with the same structure.
`Notes/*.iwnote`	Note files. A Vault that already has a `노트` folder (the Korean default) keeps using it.
`.iwae/`	App records: highlights, bookmarks, search index, translation cache, history, sessions, trash

Opening and organizing documents

- Click a document in the left “Explorer” to open it in a tab. Create folders, rename and drag items to move them there too.
- Use “Add document” to import files, or drag documents from your file manager onto the Vault folder.
- The GitHub button imports a folder of Markdown documents from a repository (p. 10).
- A PDF opened from your file manager is not imported. It stays under “Recent PDFs” at the bottom left, and dragging it onto a Vault folder imports it.
- Click the Vault name at the bottom left to switch Vaults. Your page and open tabs are restored next time.

Parts of the window

Top row	The left bar view tabs, the session name, the screen tabs, the toolbar of the current pane and the translator button.
Left bar	Documents and notes, outline, thumbnails, PDF tools, search. Drag its edge to resize.
Panes	Documents and notes are all tabs, and tabs live in panes. Each pane has its own head (color dot, number, tab bar) and tools. A note scrolls in its own pane. Splitting is explained on p. 4.

Good to know Only three things leave your PC: text sent to a cloud translation service, the update check, and requests from an external AI after you turn that connection on. Details are on p. 11.

Try it

1. In the left “Explorer”, click **Markdown example** to open it in a new tab.
2. Click the tabs to switch between this guide and the Markdown example.
3. Create a folder with “New folder” and rename it “Practice”. You can delete it afterwards.

2 Tabs, panes, screens

Every document gets a tab. Tabs live in panes, and you split panes to read several documents side by side.

Pane	Where tabs gather. Each pane has its own tab bar and tools.
Screen	A set of panes. Switch screens with the screen tabs in the top row (“0 Read”, “1 Compare”).
Session	Several screens saved under a name. Switch and save from the session name in the top row.

Split panes with the prefix key

Press the prefix key (`Ctrl`+`B` by default), release it, then press one of the keys below. The “…” menu in a pane head does the same things. After 2 seconds, or on `Esc`, it cancels.

Panes	`%` split left-right, `"` split top-bottom, `←` `↑` `→` `↓` move, `z` zoom this pane (again to restore), `x` close, `{` `}` swap, `Space` cycle layouts, `q` jump by number
Screens	`!` move the pane to a new screen, `c` new screen, `n` `p` next and previous screen, `0` to `9` jump by number
Other	`f` hide or show floating panes, `w` open or close the translator, `?` keys and commands

If your input method gets in the way, type a command such as `split-window -h` in the command palette (`Ctrl`+`K`).

New screens and floating panes

- “New screen” in the top row adds a screen. Templates: “Reading”, “Note on the left”, “Compare” and “Blank screen”.
- “Float” in a pane head's “…” menu lifts the pane over the screen. Drag its head to move it and a corner to resize it.

Rearrange by dragging

Drag a tab within a pane	Reorders the tabs.
Drag a tab to another pane's tab bar	Moves the tab to that pane.
Drag a tab to a pane edge	Drag a tab to the edge of a pane and a new pane appears on that side.
Drag a tab out of the window	It becomes a new app window. Drag it back onto a tab bar or choose “Reattach” to return it.
Drag a pane head	Drop it on another pane to swap the two, or on an edge to split there and move it.

New window (`Ctrl`+`Shift`+`N`) is a second app window on the same session. What you highlight or write in one shows up in the other, and edits to the same file are merged instead of overwriting each other.

Viewing and moving around

- Page layout: single page, two pages, three pages or continuous scroll. The bottom bar sets fit and zoom.
- `Ctrl`+`G` goes to a page. Hover a link to preview it and click to follow it.

Try it

1. Open the “…” menu in the document pane head and choose “Split to the right”.
2. Drag the **Markdown example** tab into the new pane and read the two documents side by side.
3. Drag a tab out of the window to detach it, then drag it back onto a tab bar.

3 Highlights and memos

Reading and marking happen in one motion. Select text, and a memo opens in the note.

Try it 1

1. On the toolbar, check that “Select text” is on (it is by default). If no note is visible, press `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `M` to open one beside the document.
2. Drag over a practice sentence below. A highlight appears and a memo opens in the note.
3. Write a memo, scroll far away, then click the memo card. The PDF returns to the highlighted sentence.

Practice 1 When you highlight a sentence you stop at, it becomes a memo card in the note.

Practice 2 A highlighted sentence is linked to its memo card by a thin line.

Practice 3 Click a memo card and the PDF returns to the highlighted sentence.

When you select text

Drag with Select text	Paints a highlight and opens a memo.
Drag with the Hand tool	Selects text without highlighting, for copying.
Buttons above a selection	Copy, Copy with source, Search documents, Translate
Click a highlight	Opens its memo card in the note so you can edit it, opening the note beside the document if it is not visible. A highlight that is in no note gets a small popover to change the color, write a memo or delete it.
Click a memo card's source	The PDF jumps to the spot. “Show in source” in the card menu does the same, and “Delete highlight and memo” removes it.

Colors

The “Highlight” tool paints color without a memo. The default colors are the four below. In Settings, under Display & documents, add named colors (up to eight) and drag them to reorder. If you delete a color, highlights painted with it stay as “Other”.

Yellow · Green · Blue · Pink · Your own colors, up to 8

Color channels and connector lines

The color dot in a pane head is its color channel: blue, green, orange or None. Panes with the same color are linked. When a document pane and a note pane share a color, a line in the highlight's color joins each highlight to its memo card, even if the panes are not side by side; where the line crosses another pane it passes over it faintly. Click the dot to change the color, or drag it onto another pane to link it. A card whose document is not shown in any pane of the same color shows “→ document name”. The eye button on the toolbar, “Hide all marks”, hides highlights, memos and lines at once. Undo (`Ctrl` + `Z`) reverts changes to highlights, drawings and memo notes without touching what another window added.

Try it 2

1. Switch to the “Highlight” tool, pick a color and paint a few sentences.
2. Click a highlighted sentence to see its card open in the note, then delete it with “Delete highlight and memo” in the card menu. Hide the marks with the eye button, then show them again.

4 Capture, box memos, drawing

Capture what is not text, such as tables and figures, and write or draw on the page.

Region capture

Choose “Region capture” on the toolbar and box a table or figure. It goes into the note as an image with a description field. A captured box can be resized by dragging its edges and corners. Holding `Ctrl` while dragging also boxes a table or figure. On a scanned page with no text layer, the text read by OCR is attached too.

Tool	Key	Use
Pen	`P`	Draw by hand
Text box	`T`	Write on the page
Eraser	`E`	Erase marks

Table 1. Three tools

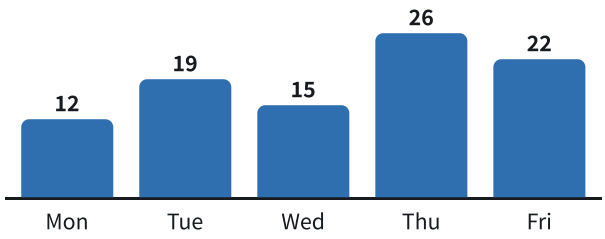


Figure 1. Pages read per weekday

Box memos and drawing

A “Box memo” attaches a memo box in the page margin, joined by a line. “Text box”, “Pen”, the drawing tools (line, arrow, rectangle, ellipse) and “Eraser” write on the PDF directly; a format box sets color and thickness. The eraser removes highlights and box memos as well as drawings.

One-key shortcuts `T` text box · `P` pen · `L` line · `A` arrow · `R` rectangle · `O` ellipse · `X` redact · `E` eraser · `Esc` tool off (outside text fields)

Drawing practice area: draw with the pen, place a text box or attach a box memo here

Try it

1. Turn on “Region capture” and box Figure 1 above. When the image lands in the note, type a description.
2. Drag an edge or corner of the box to resize it.
3. Attach a “Box memo” in the margin, press `P` and draw in the practice area, then press `E` to erase. `Esc` turns the tool off.

5 Notes and tickets

A note is a document built from blocks. One note can mix memos from several PDFs and Markdown files.

Block	Description
Section	Groups the blocks under it. Collapse it, or drag it and the blocks under it move together.
Text	Free writing in the note, with bold, lists, tables and code.
Memo	Your comment with its sources (page numbers) underneath. Click a source to jump to the PDF. A memo can hold several sources, captures included.
Ticket	A memo with an ID and a title, for tracking requirements.

Drag the handle on the left to change the order of blocks. Select several blocks with `Ctrl` or `Shift`+click and drag them together.

Drop blocks onto a note open in another pane to move them there. Hold `Alt` when you drop to link instead, and the original note is unchanged. `Esc` cancels.

ID and title (tickets)

Memos can carry an ID and a title. Hover a memo to see + ID and + Title at the top right, or start the memo with something like `REQ-04` to turn it into an ID. IWAE suggests the next number and warns about an ID already used in the note.

Below are practice requirements. Highlight one line at a time to make a memo, then give it an ID.

REQ-01	Saved notes must still be there after the app restarts.
REQ-02	Deleting a highlight must also remove its memo block from the note.
REQ-03	Highlights must point to the same text after pages are reordered.
REQ-04	Text to translate must only be sent where the user chose.

The example note in this Vault already holds REQ-01 and REQ-03 as tickets.

Working with note panes

Open note	Click the arrow beside the note tab title to list this PDF's notes and other notes. The note you pick opens as a tab. You can also create a note for this PDF or move this note to the trash there. The magnifier searches all memos.
Notes per PDF	Expand the caret on a PDF row in the left “Explorer” to see that PDF's notes under it, and create new ones there.
Wide view	Drag the note pane wide (about 460px and up) and it becomes a wide column with an outline. Good for organizing and polishing. Narrow it again for the card list.
Expand all memos	Opens or closes the quoted source text on every memo card at once. “Insert text block” (+) adds free writing to the note.

Try it

1. Highlight the REQ-02 sentence to make a memo, then press “+ ID” on it and enter REQ-02. Add a title with “+ Title”.
2. Drag the note pane wide to see the outline, then narrow it again.

6 Left bar, library, versions

Five tabs at the left of the top row are how you find and skim documents.

Explorer	The Vault's documents and notes. Open documents get a dot, and the selected document and note are marked.
Outline	The outline and bookmarks of this PDF. Click one to go to that page.
Thumbnails	Page thumbnails. A rectangle shows the area now in view.
PDF tools	OCR, compare, merge and more (p. 9).
Search	Switch between “This document” and “All documents”. Options for case (Aa) and whole word (W). Click a result to open it at that spot.

Searching all documents covers file names, folders, PDF text and Markdown content together. Pages without a text layer are read locally with OCR and indexed.

Expand the library

The library button at the top of the left bar (`Ctrl`+`Shift`+`L`) turns the left bar into navigation (All, Favorites, Recently opened, folders) and fills the area on the right with a table of every document.

- Edit paper details such as title, authors and year in the table, sort, star documents and group them into collections. Switch between list and card views.
- Paper details are filled in from the PDF or Crossref, and you can copy a BibTeX citation.

Versions

Group the draft, revised and final files of one document as its versions and switch between them. Use “Group with another file as versions…” on a file row; ungrouping leaves the files as they are. The PDF tool “Compare text with another version” (p. 9) shows only what changed between two versions, side by side.

Zoom each bar separately

`Ctrl`+wheel over the left bar, a note pane (card list view) or the library zooms each one separately between 80% and 150%. The values are saved and do not affect PDF zoom. The size of the whole interface is set under “Interface size” in Settings.

Try it

1. In “Outline”, click a heading to go to a chapter, then watch the rectangle follow in “Thumbnails”.
2. Press `Ctrl`+`Shift`+`F`, search “All documents” for `Vault` and click a result.
3. Expand and collapse the library with `Ctrl`+`Shift`+`L`. Try `Ctrl`+wheel over the left bar as well.

7 PDF tools

Open the “PDF tools” tab in the left bar and each tool unfolds there. Only Edit pages takes over the PDF pane.

Most tools let you choose “Apply to original” or “As a copy”, and a copy is saved as a new PDF in the Vault. Edit pages backs up the original first. You can also open a tool by typing its name in the command palette (`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `P`).

Group	Tool	What it does
Text	**Add text layer with OCR**	Adds a text layer to scanned pages so they can be searched and selected. Runs on your PC.
	Compare text with another version	Compares the text of two versions and shows only what changed, side by side.
My marks	**Marks-flattened copy**	Builds a PDF with your highlights, memos and drawings merged into the pages. Use it when sharing.
	Redacted copy	Removes the text and images under redaction boxes drawn with the redact tool (`X`) for good.
Pages	**Edit pages**	Reorder, rotate, remove, insert pages from another PDF. Highlights follow their pages.
	Extract pages to new PDF	Pulls a page range into a new PDF.
	Split by chapters	Splits the PDF at each outline chapter.
	Merge with other PDFs	Combines several PDFs into one.
	Remove blank pages	Finds blank pages and drops them.
	Fix scanned page orientation	Straightens sideways and upside-down scanned pages, found with OCR.
Layout	**Add page numbers**	Pick the position and style of page numbers.
	Watermark	Stamps text on every page.
	Crop margins	Trims page margins.
	N-up	Puts several pages on one sheet.
	Compress	Shrinks oversized images and only writes a file that is smaller.
Export	**Pages as PNG**	Saves pages as image files.
	Text as Markdown	Extracts the PDF's text as Markdown.
	Unlocked copy	Makes a copy without a password after you enter it. Password-protected PDFs ask for it when opened.

Try it

1. Open the “PDF tools” tab in the left bar, click “Add page numbers” and look at the position and style options. It starts on “Apply to original”. Choose “As a copy” first and only a copy is made.
2. Open “Compare text with another version” and compare this guide with another PDF of the same document, after adding one to the Vault.

8 Translation and Markdown

Translate just the text you select and read it beside the original, which is never replaced.

Translation

Select text and press “Translate” in the buttons that appear. A result card opens with the language, the translation method, retry, and copy with the original. Each source line in a note has a small translate button that shows the translation under it. Text broken across lines is joined before translating, and text that is already in the target language is translated into another one.

The **translator** is a panel that floats over the app window. Open or close it with the translator button in the top row or the prefix key followed by `w`. It takes text selected in a document or text you type (`Ctrl`+`Enter` translates), and you resize it by dragging a corner. Turning off “Use translation” in Settings hides the Translate buttons and the translator.

Method	What to know
Local (Ollama)	Translates on your own PC. Nothing leaves the machine. It can be slow, depending on the model.
Cloud	Google Translate (no key), Azure Translator, DeepL, OpenAI, Anthropic or Gemini. The selected text is sent to the service you choose.

Practice 4 Cloud API keys are stored in this PC's credential store.

Translation cache: a text translated once into the same language is reused from storage, without another request. Turn it off or clear it under Translation in Settings. Translations stay in the Vault's `.iwae` folder. The method and API keys are set there too.

A paragraph to translate

Practice 5 Una lista de lectura bien ordenada convierte artículos dispersos en un argumento. Marca la afirmación, anota por qué importa y vuelve a la fuente cuando dudes de tu propio resumen.

Markdown documents

Markdown files open in tabs next to your PDFs, with headings, tables, code, task lists and an outline. Highlights, memos and region captures work just as in a PDF, and the memos mix into the same note. Change the look under “Markdown document theme” in Settings; the original file is never changed.

- **From GitHub:** the GitHub button above the left “Explorer” imports a folder of Markdown documents from a repository. You are told when there are new commits. Pull the latest, or open an older version from a branch, tag or commit.

Try it

1. Select the Spanish paragraph (Practice 5) and press “Translate”. Translate the same paragraph again and it comes from the cache.
2. Highlight it as a memo, then press the translate button on the card's source line in the note.
3. On the **Markdown example** tab, highlight a sentence to add a memo to the same note.

9 Look, settings, your data

Open Settings with `Ctrl`+`,`.

Themes and color

Theme	System, Light or Dark. System follows your operating system.
Color scheme	Default, Neutral gray, Warm paper or Deep navy. With “New theme” you set just eight base colors per brightness and the rest are derived, with a live preview and contrast warnings. Themes can be exported and imported as files, duplicated and deleted.
Accent color	Blue, teal, green, purple, rose or amber, or pick any color of your own; you are warned when contrast is too low.
Highlight colors	Create named colors, up to eight, and drag them to reorder.
Size, language	Interface size 90–125%, Korean, English or system language, and six Markdown document themes.
Prefix key	Under “Shortcuts & mouse”, choose Ctrl+B (default), Ctrl+Space or Ctrl+A, or set your own.

Your data stays on your PC

Safe saves	Files are written to a temporary file and replaced in one step, and a journal detects interrupted writes. Earlier states are kept for a limited time, and conflicting edits are kept side by side for you to choose.
Trash	Deleted items go to `.iwae/trash/` first.
Automatic backup	Turn it on under “Data & recovery”. On the days you pick, the whole Vault is zipped into a folder, and only the number of backups you set are kept.
Several app windows	App windows on one Vault merge their changes instead of overwriting each other.
API keys	Kept in the operating system's credential store, not in the Vault.

What leaves your PC Only text sent to a cloud translation service, the update check, and requests from an external AI after you turn that on. The external AI connection is off by default. When on, it listens only on `127.0.0.1` and needs a token.

External AI and updates

- **External AI connection:** IWAE has no built-in chat. An outside agent such as Claude Code can use your Vault through an MCP server: search it, read pages, add and change memos. Turn it on under “External AI connection” and run the command shown once. It cannot change your PDF files.
- **Updates:** Under “Updates”, choose automatic checks and pre-downloading. The signature is verified, and installation starts only when you confirm it.

Try it

1. Open Settings with `Ctrl`+`,`, switch to Dark, then click a color scheme and an accent to see the screen change.
2. Add a named color under highlight colors and use it to highlight a sentence on this page.
3. Open the command palette with `Ctrl`+`Shift`+`P` and type “dark” or “new window”.

10 Shortcuts and mouse

On macOS use ⌘ instead of Ctrl. The same list is under “Shortcuts & mouse” in Settings.

General

Ctrl + Shift + P	Command palette (Ctrl + K too)
Ctrl + B	Prefix key (waits for the next key)
Ctrl + Shift + N	New window
Ctrl + ,	Settings
Ctrl + F	Find in this document
Ctrl + Shift + F	Search all documents
Ctrl + Shift + L	Toggle library
Ctrl + Z	Undo
Ctrl + Shift + Z	Redo (Ctrl + Y)

Tabs and documents

Ctrl + Tab	Next tab (add Shift for previous)
Ctrl + W	Close tab
Ctrl + \	Change the number of panes (1, 2, 3)
Ctrl + Shift + M	Open or close a note beside the document
Ctrl + G	Go to page
Ctrl + P	Print
Alt + ← →	Back, forward (document jumps)
Ctrl +wheel	Zoom the PDF (over the left bar or a note, only that one)
Ctrl +drag	Box a table or figure on the PDF to capture it

Marking tools (one key, outside text fields)

T text box · P pen · L line · A arrow · R rectangle · O ellipse · X redact · E eraser · Esc tool off. You can turn these off in Settings. In note text, Ctrl + B is bold, Ctrl + I italic and Ctrl + U underline.

Mouse

Mouse back, forward buttons	Move through your document jump history. Use them after following a link.
Draw with the right button held	↓ to the bottom, ↑ to the top, ← back, → forward, ⌞ close tab, ¬ reopen closed tab. Release without moving for the usual context menu.
Drag a tab or pane head	Reorder, move between panes, split at an edge, or pull out into a new app window (p. 4).
Drag a memo block	Moves it to another note. Hold Alt when you drop to link it (p. 7).

Wrap-up

1. Did you highlight this guide, see a memo appear in the note, and click the card to jump back? (p. 5)
2. Did you capture Figure 1, give a requirement an ID and translate the Spanish paragraph? (6, 7, 10)
3. Now drop your own PDF into the Vault folder and read it the same way. To report a problem or suggest a feature, open an issue on the repository. IWAE is open source.